

During the first few months of retirement you'll likely receive job offers. That's when your business associates hear about your new life and have your name fresh in their minds. They'll invariably come up with something you can do. In my case I got an inquiry from Washington, D.C., within a week of resigning from Peat Marwick. The job was a lower-level presidential appointment in the Treasury Department. A week after that an American firm called to see if I wanted to represent their products in Argentina. I was tempted to follow up. But I believe it would have been a mistake. Part of retiring is breaking the old work habit. That takes time. You'll never know what a good thing you've got going if you give it up after a month and go back to work.

My friend Sam recovered from his consulting disaster and decided to learn something about political campaigns. He drove to a campaign headquarters in a small town south of Houston, met the candidate, and signed up. His first job was doing phone solicitations, but after two weeks Sam began to take over day-to-day operations. He checked that prepaid ads ran as scheduled, called people to get them to donate restaurants and clubs for rallies, arranged coffee meetings in people's homes on Sunday mornings, and got posters printed.

Sam thoroughly enjoyed himself, but the candidate lost, and Sam went knocking around for something else to do. That's when he made his second mistake. He bought retail space in a shopping center in northern Houston and leased it to others.

"Looking back on it, I think I wanted an anchor in my life," Sam told me. "The anchor used to be my job. I identified with being chief financial officer of an oil company. When I retired I needed something to replace that anchor. Real estate is tangible, physical, something I could relate to. Besides that retail space, I considered buying other real estate: a new house, farmland, and a mansion in West Texas. I managed to keep from doing so. But in total I probably lost \$60,000 on the retail space. Stupid."

The rule is: